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Book Author(s): Howard W. Stone and James O. Duke

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Theological Method

The debate over abortion and reproductive choice. Concern over stem-cell research. A selection from the writings of a medieval theologian. The decision of a terminally ill patient to be allowed to die without heroic measures. The funding of a new Christian education wing to the church. The United States government's policies about refugees. The use of behavior modification in the counseling of children. These, and other such issues, are subjects for theological reflection. Texts, activities, situations, and events outside and within the church also benefit from theological analysis and theological construction.

Since virtually anything is a potential object of theological reflection, how are we to choose what deserves our attention? It would seem fundamental that Christians would want to reflect on their understanding of the Christian message of God. But since their understanding of God's message is worked out in the context of the church, there is also good reason to reflect on the nature of the church. Then again, daily life presents us with many personal, social, and political issues that cannot be avoided. The fact is, we are rarely afforded the leisure to choose what issue upon which to reflect first. More often than not, they hit us in the face.

- Where do you begin?
- How do you proceed?

- How do you develop a theological template?
- How do you prioritize the issues of theology in their order of importance?

Issues such as these belong to an area of theology called *theological method*, which examines the bases, proper ordering, and norms of theology. Some theologians specialize in theological method and devote entire books to it. Others—perhaps most of them—alert the reader to their method in the introductory remarks and then go on to present the content of their theology. There are even theologians who simply plunge into their theology without advising anyone of the method being used.

Theological method: examines the bases, proper ordering, and norms of theology.

It is not our intention to survey the leading methods current in theology or to propose one as best. Becoming deliberative about theological reflection, however, does involve paying attention to the methods used by other theologians. Conscientious theologians will also want to become clear about the particular theological method they are following.

THE STARTING POINT OF THEOLOGY

Christian theology is reflection on the faith in the Christian message of God in Jesus Christ. The connection between faith and God's message is an invitation to reflect either on the human side of the connection (faith) or on its divine side (God's message).

These two tracks have given rise to a distinction between theologies with an *anthropological* or *human*

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starting point and those that begin with *divine revelation*. An anthropological starting point leads theologians to look first at Christian faith in the context of human living and then seek to ascertain the meaning of God's message to the world. Theologies with a revelatory starting point typically begin by focusing on the message of God as revealed in Scripture and/or tradition, only then moving on to explore its human implications.

The question of starting point is a significant one.

Where theologians begin influences where their theological reflections will lead them. Each starting point has its merits but also its risks. An anthropological starting point acknowledges that Christian faith develops within the concrete, specific setting of human life. But anthropologically oriented theologians must be on guard lest their views become governed more by their personal, social, or cultural milieu than by the distinctiveness of the Christian message.

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For its part, a revelatory starting point has the merit of acknowledging that God's message alone determines the character and content of an authentically Christian faith. But theologians working from the sources of revelation need to

avoid the very real danger of confusing God's revelation itself with their own fallible grasp of it. The temptation to do so is seductive and perhaps impossible to avoid entirely. They also have to be concerned that in focusing on divine revelation they clearly set forth how it relates to the lives of people in the world of today.

In actual practice, those who go about theological reflection—laypeople, ministers, and academic theologians alike—inevitably take as their starting point who and where they are, here and now. This might be construed as an anthropological starting point except for the fact of who and where Christians are: persons of faith, members of a church, and familiar to some degree with Scripture, tradition, and the language of faith. They have already gathered from their Christian involvements some initial understanding of the meaning of the Christian message.

Starting points include life situations in which Christians find themselves: happy in marriage, worried about their children, hoping for a promotion at work, strapped for money, worried that the politicians have the nation on the wrong track, active in a recycling project. They may feel that they are faithful Christians—less than saintly perhaps, but trying to do the best they can. As church members they attend worship, sing in the choir, bake brownies for the coffee hour, donate time and money to the community hospice. The problems of the outside world infiltrate the church. The congregation seems divided between the members who would like to keep those problems at bay and others who urge responding to them with increased funding and new programs for outreach.

Every one of these matters represents a starting point for theology. They prompt us to reflect on what it means to be faithful to the Christian message of God

in these situations. And that involves seeking to understand the meaning of that message.

The starting point for our theology determines where we will go from there, and how we will view even the most seemingly mundane issues theologically. This is illustrated by a controversy that erupted in the council meeting of a suburban Protestant church. The subject under discussion was the adoption of a new hymnal. For years the congregation had been using hymnbooks inherited from another church; many people thought the hymns were outdated and all agreed the books were in poor repair.

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The denominational loyalists on the council argued, “Christians should stand for something, and if we stand for anything we have to stand up for our church; we can’t go on using somebody else’s hymns.” The opposition retorted, “If we’re Christian, people ought to matter more than hymnbooks and any extra money we have should be given to Meals-on-

Wheels or some other charity.” Another council member argued, “We’ll never attract young people when our hymns use sexist language.” Finally, the budget chair pointed out, “We simply can’t afford it.” Her dollars-and-cents view won the day, but not the argument. The shouting continued when a council member accused, “All you think about is money,” and the budget chair responded, “Christian stewardship means making tough choices; it’s a sin to waste money.”

Everyone who attended the meeting, or heard about it via the grapevine, had an opinion. Some categorized their views as theological positions; others billed theirs

as plain common sense. And there were a few church members on both sides of the issue who observed that "God couldn't care less if we use hymnbooks or not."

The Great Hymnal Controversy is by no means complete as a model of the day-to-day task of theological reflection. Nor is it unique. Tom, for example, had never given much thought to death, let alone a theological view of death and dying, until his mother was diagnosed with terminal cancer three years ago. The term *euthanasia* makes him cringe, bringing to his mind Nazi concentration camps. But last week the doctor said something about withdrawing life support. Tom is overwhelmed; he doesn't know what to think or do. He cannot remember any sermons or church school lessons that addressed terminal illness, except a vague understanding from his early childhood that good people go to heaven when they die. He does recall a visiting speaker during College Week a few years ago who caused quite a row when he commented in passing, "Heaven or Hell, Christianity is for the living, not the dead." One evening Tom looked for the word *cancer* or a synonym in the Bible but couldn't find it.

Tom has been giving a lot of thought to what God wills for his mother. It may not be a good time for him to join a discussion group on theology, but circumstances have forced him to reflect theologically nevertheless. One hopes that he will seek out the counsel of his pastor or a lay friend who has already done some deliberative theological thinking on the issue with which he is struggling. One might also hope that his Christian advisor will know something about cancer, death and dying, life-support systems, and hospital routines as well.

The topics of theological reflection are infinitely varied and, as in Tom's case, ordinarily are chosen for us by our life situation. This is true even of the most

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scholarly theologies, which often make no mention at all of the real-world setting and proceed in a manner apparently detached from events around them. All theology is context-related in the sense that its understanding of faith reflects conditions in the life of the theologian.

CREATIVE THEOLOGY

Whether or not God cares which hymnal a church uses for its Sunday worship, issues like these inevitably come up, every week, in thousands of churches. They can't be wished away; they have to be dealt with. Tom's quandary is less mundane and clearly more urgent. It also cannot be wished away. Whether or not his theology is adequate to the task, he will have to make a decision, and most likely he will ruminate on that decision for the remainder of his life.

It is not difficult to see that when theologians go about thinking, they have to be thinking creatively. Theology is not data crunching. It comes down to issues like Tom's decision about his mother or the Great Hymnal Controversy. We need the facts, to be sure; we also need imagination. We are dealing with meaning, with human need, with our connectedness to God and to one another, with God's intervention in our lives.

In forging an approach to theological reflection that is creative as well as critical, it may be helpful to look at different ways in which our minds deal with information.

Two Modes of Thinking

Sequential thinking is linear cognitive information processing: *A* leads to *B*, *B* leads to *C*, and so on. Sequential thinking functions logically and analytically. It compares, analyzes, measures, and judges. It orders things successively or chronologically.

Parallel synthetic thinking sees the total picture or *gestalt* and the interrelatedness of its parts. It processes information all at once, without separately considering each individual factor. It is able to see the interrelationships of a number of factors at the same time without sequentially ordering them. It is adept at the cognitive organization of data that is needed for the perception and interpretation of a painting or photograph. Many bits of data are processed at the same time.

Sequential thinking:
linear thinking
that orders things
successively or
chronologically.

Each of these modes of thinking participates in most activities. They work in partnership to provide the total cognitive functioning of the person. Each mode of cognition has the ability to inhibit the other in order to solve a problem. Our minds switch between these two ways of thinking, choosing the most suitable one and inhibiting the other. Sequential thinking and parallel synthetic thinking *complement* each other, but do not replace one another. Creative thinking involves developing the proficiency of each type of cognition as well as learning to give attention to both modes of thinking.

Most of us have a natural leaning toward either sequential or parallel synthetic thinking. To some extent we may have to live with our inborn tendency; no one's thinking is entirely one way or the other. For

Parallel synthetic thinking: thinking that processes information all at once as a totality (a *gestalt*) without separately examining each of the interrelated components.

For theology to be creative, the output of parallel synthetic thinking needs to be integrated with the conceptual constructs of sequential thinking and vice versa.

theology to be creative, the output of parallel synthetic thinking needs to be integrated with the conceptual constructs of sequential thinking and vice versa. Theological reflection requires both modes of cognitive encoding of data (thinking) for it to be creative.

Creative Thinking

It is possible to create conditions within our environments and schedules, and to structure stages of theological reflection, whereby the fullest possible use is made of both types of cognition (researchers have called this *bilateral cognition*).

We refer to the integration of the two modes of thinking as *creative thinking* simply because creativity requires both cognitive approaches. Imagination is play, and it is also discipline. Creativity is inspiration, brought on by research. Creativity is listening and questioning.

Those whose bias is toward parallel synthetic thinking will be able to realize the benefits of sequential cognition by balancing their intuitive style with disciplined scholarship and logical, measurable verification of insights.¹ People involved in day-to-day ministry sometimes fail to give adequate attention to preparation (that is, information gathering and analysis), even dismissing it as a purely head-level operation. As a result, the theological constructs of deliberative theology may have little or no effect on the tasks of ministry; and their

pastoral work occurs only out of an embedded theology. These people can do some “pump-priming” activities to enhance the sequential components of their theological reflection. Such activities may include daily readings in Scripture and theology that actively work toward the continued development of a deliberative theology.

Creative thinking: the integration of linear and parallel synthetic thinking.

Another sequential task that some Christians neglect is verification. In this connection, the sequential mode of thinking can be fostered by the simple method of putting one’s insights into written form. (There is a reason professors require so many written papers: writing helps to clarify one’s thinking.) The experiences of ministry are indeed raw material for theological formulation, but only if the Christian as theologian takes the time—if necessary, scheduled and rigorously observed—to articulate and test insights gained from that experience. Verification is further enhanced through sharing our reflected insights—through preaching, teaching, and writing—with others who might profit from them. It is engaging in theological conversation. Deliberative theological reflection is a communal task; verification requires sharing our thoughts with others.

Similarly, individuals who find themselves more prone to sequential modes of information processing need to stop the incessant analyzing that can stifle imagination and impede understanding. They need to be receptive to insights that come to them while they are not overtly working on a specific problem, and to trust and nurture these discoveries.

Listening to music, playing the piano, gardening, meditating, walking or jogging, painting, or even such

Deliberative theological reflection is a communal task; verification requires sharing our thoughts with others.

mindless undertakings as folding the Sunday bulletin or washing dishes, can allow parallel thinking to occur. Spiritual disciplines also benefit the intuitive thought processes so necessary to theological reflection. Structuring one's schedule to include

a number of pump-priming activities of parallel synthetic cognition will enrich our creative thinking.

The *ah-ha* can arrive in a variety of forms—a visual image, a sudden recollection, a burst of ideas. In a pastoral visit it may appear as a childhood memory, a parable, or a story from Scripture bubbling to the surface of consciousness. Whenever it comes, we need to recognize it, seize it, listen to it, use it.

Reflection that is theological reflection is creative. It relies upon both sequential and parallel synthetic cognitive processing. Christians as theologians at times have to enhance their abilities for creative thinking by doing pump-priming activities. Theological reflection is an imaginative, craftlike enterprise.

A RUDIMENTARY PROCEDURE

Theological reflection is a creative process. It pays attention to where we begin—the starting point. The question remains, *How do we begin?* What is involved as we go about the task of deliberative theological reflection upon the Great Hymnal Controversy or the decision regarding life support for a dying parent or any other issue that confronts us? Is there a procedure the council members could have used to make their deliberations smoother and—more important—enriching to their

faith? Are there some basic elements Tom can get a grasp on, to give him a sense of order in his confusion?

This much, at least, is called for as we deliberate theologically on the questions and struggles of our Christian lives:

- to make explicit the theological understandings of the Christian message implicit in the discussion;
- to examine those understandings and note their strengths and limits;
- to propose what seems the most adequate resolution to the issue in light of the Christian message of God; and
- to explain in theological terms why what we propose is preferable to other options.

The first two tasks are primarily functions of *theological analysis*, which is the investigative side of theological method that sets out to discover the understanding of faith implicit or explicit within any issue. The latter two tasks fall under the heading of *theological construction*, which strives to interpret matters in light of the Christian message. Both tasks are essential in creative deliberative theological reflection, and in practice are interrelated and carried out together.

There was no list of church council discussion topics from which the Great Hymnal Controversy was selected. Nor did Tom pick the subject of artificial life support for his dying mother from a menu of life crises calling for theological reflection. To repeat: The subjects for our theological reflection have a tendency to choose themselves. Given that, we need to know what to look for in the theologies of others, or in responding to real-life issues in our own lives, that will help us approach our theological reflection in an orderly and not haphazard fashion.

Theological analysis: the investigative side of theology that seeks to sort out and evaluate the understanding of faith implicit or explicit in any given statement and/or action.

Theological construction: the synthetic (integrative) side of theology that seeks to fashion a fresh exposition of the meaning of faith in the Christian message.

The following three chapters will propose three sets of diagnostic exercises—questions, really—that can serve as the basis of a procedure for doing theological reflection and will facilitate the analytical and constructive theological tasks. The first set looks at the issue in light of the *gospel*; the second in terms of the *human condition*; and the third diagnostic set examines the implications of *Christian vocation* as they bear on the matter at hand.

The subjects for our theological reflection have a tendency to choose themselves.

Each question in turn (though not necessarily in order) can be applied to every issue that calls for our theological deliberation. The exercises surely will not cover all that could be said about the meaning of the Christian message of God. But they strike near the very heart of the concerns of Christian faith. In exploring these questions, something is disclosed of the breadth and depth of the Christian message. They provide a staging area for later, more complete, reflection.

None of these tasks or exercises is to be thought of as a rigid rule for the theological enterprise. They are,

instead, guides. They can help us through the fractious chaos of a skirmish in congregational affairs or the bewildering chaos of a life-or-death decision. A theological method can bring some order to that chaos—not order for its own sake, but for the confidence that our views and actions are in keeping with our Christian faith. They make it possible for the Christian message of God to have an impact upon the mundane as well as the crucial matters of our lives.

QUESTIONS FOR REFLECTION

1. Why is it important to understand one's theological point of origin?
2. Which track do you best identify with—anthropological or revelatory? Why?
3. What are the risks that face a community of faith when it attempts to ignore pressing social issues? Identify the risks when a community intentionally tries to develop ministries based on such needs.
4. How would you describe your denomination/local church regarding social issues? Where on a continuum between *ignore* or *embrace* do you find it?
5. Which thinking mode suits you best: *sequential* or *parallel synthetic*?
6. How important is it to understand your basic mode of thinking? Why or why not?
7. To what degree does your community of faith discourage or embrace creative thinking and questioning?
8. Are there any areas within your community of faith's discipline where questioning is "out of the question" (i.e., biblical interpretation and tradition)?

FOR FURTHER READING

- Saliers, Don E. *Worship as Theology: Foretaste of Glory Divine*. Nashville: Abingdon Press, 1994. Saliers, one of today's most theologically insightful writers on worship, explores the God-centered and human-oriented dimensions of Christian worship.
- Thistlethwaite, Susan Brooks, and Mary Potter Engel. *Lift Every Voice: Constructing Christian Theologies from the Underside*, rev. and expanded ed. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1998. A multinational, multiethnic, multiracial, and otherwise diverse list of distinguished contributors discuss their current thinking on classic Christian doctrines and issues.
- White, James F. *A Brief History of Christian Worship*. Nashville: Abingdon Press, 1993. Much of Christian theology arises from worship and is most at home there. White's is a classic survey of worship in Christianity's major church traditions.
- Wilson-Dickson, Andrew. *The Story of Christian Music*. Minneapolis: Fortress Press; Oxford: Lion Books, 2003. Christians in every congregation can put their own theology and church practices of music and hymn-singing in proper historical and cultural context, thanks to this wide-ranging overview of church music.

NOTE

- 1 See Graham Wallas, *The Art of Thought* (London: Solis Press, 2014).

